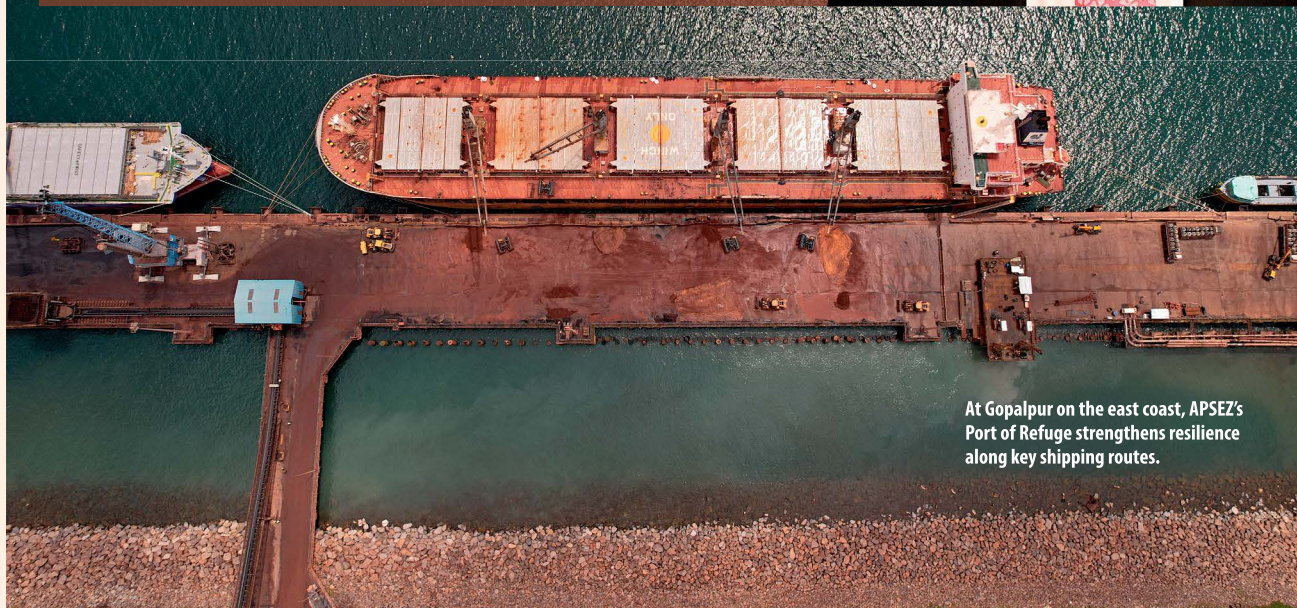
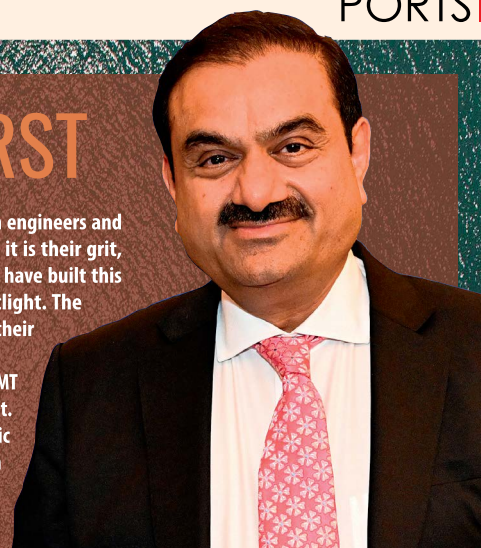


SCALE, SPIRIT, NATION FIRST

As Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) recently crossed the 500 million metric tonnes (MMT) milestone, Chairman Mr Gautam Adani described it not as a measure of scale, but as a moment shaped by belief, perseverance and shared purpose. Calling it a deeply personal milestone, he reflected on a journey that began in Mundra, Gujarat, where conviction took root against the odds and grew into a global network powering trade, logistics and national progress. What started as a distant vision has today become a living system that connects industries, fuels growth and mirrors India's rising ambition.

At its core, he said, are people. From engineers and marine teams to frontline workers, it is their grit, discipline and quiet dedication that have built this institution, often far from the spotlight. The milestone, he noted, is a tribute to their efforts and belief.

The message was clear. The first 500 MMT is not the summit, but the starting point. As India enters a new phase of economic expansion, APSEZ is poised to scale with purpose, shaping the infrastructure that will power the nation's next chapter.



At Gopalpur on the east coast, APSEZ's Port of Refuge strengthens resilience along key shipping routes.

11,000 kilometres of coastline and proximity to major trade arteries linking West Asia, Europe and Asia, India's exposure to maritime risk is considerable.

APSEZ's initiative creates a structured response system where none existed before. In practical terms, it means ships facing emergencies such as fires, structural damage or oil spills now have designated locations where they can seek assistance without delay.

The company has identified two strategic sites. On the west coast, Dighi Port in Maharashtra, positioned along key Arabian Sea routes and close to traffic moving towards the Persian Gulf, will serve as a critical refuge point. On the east coast, Gopalpur Port in Odisha, located along the Bay of Bengal and near shipping lanes leading to the Malacca Strait, one of the world's busiest maritime trade corridors, will support vessels navigating this critical route.

Together, these ports provide geographic balance, enabling emergency response coverage across both coasts.

From Infrastructure to Integrated Response

What sets the initiative apart is not just the designation of ports, but the ecosystem built around them.

The PoR framework is supported by a tripartite memorandum of understanding (MoU) between APSEZ, SMIT Salvage, the global salvage and emergency response arm of Royal

Boskalis Westminster N.V., and the Marine Emergency Response Centre (MERC), a specialised maritime coordination agency. This collaboration brings global expertise, specialised equipment and coordinated response protocols into India's maritime ecosystem.

The facilities will offer a full suite of emergency services, including salvage and wreck removal, firefighting, pollution containment and real-time coordination. This is particularly important in incidents where delays can escalate risks to both human life and the environment.

The framework also aligns with international maritime conventions and supports vessels insured under the International Group of Protection and Indemnity Clubs, ensuring compatibility with global risk and liability standards. For APSEZ, the move reflects a broader shift from scale to responsibility at scale.

Why It Matters Now

The timing of the initiative is significant. Tensions in West Asia have underscored the vulnerability of global shipping lanes, with rerouting, delays and heightened risk exposure becoming more frequent. For a country like India, which depends heavily on maritime trade for energy imports and exports, resilience in shipping infrastructure is no longer optional.

A PoR reduces uncertainty during emergencies. It provides

shipowners, insurers and authorities with a clear protocol for response, helping avoid ad-hoc decisions that can worsen situations. It also plays a critical role in preventing environmental damage, particularly in cases involving hazardous cargo or fuel spills.

Globally, the absence of designated refuge points has, in the past, led to ships being denied entry to ports during crises, resulting in prolonged exposure to risk. By formalising this capability, India has signalled its readiness to align with global best practices.

A Broader Signal for Maritime India

Beyond immediate safety benefits, the initiative carries strategic implications.

As India positions itself as a key node in global supply chains, the ability to offer reliable, safe and responsive maritime infrastructure becomes a competitive advantage. Ports are no longer just transit points, they are part of a larger ecosystem that must ensure continuity, safety and environmental stewardship. APSEZ's PoR initiative reflects this evolving role. It combines infrastructure with coordination, technology and global partnerships to create a system that is both scalable and responsive.

In an era of uncertain seas, safe harbour is no longer optional, it is strategic.